

Editorial Brief

Fill-in template — write it before you talk to an editor

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Companion to Writing with Claude, Chapters 10 and 11. Write this before you talk to a single editor. Give it to Claude with your Canon, voice profile, and rules file and say: "Draft my editorial brief from these." Then rewrite the cover note and the voice section in your own words — those two are you talking, not the machine. If you end up doing the edit with Claude instead of a person, this brief becomes Claude's instructions.

Cover note (you write this)

Two or three paragraphs, in your voice. Who you are, what the book is, why you are self-publishing, what you want from the person reading this. Say plainly that you used AI in drafting and what has already been done about it. Editors find out anyway; telling them first is the credibility move.

At a glance

Field	Your book
Title / subtitle	
Author	
Genre	
Length	~ __, __ words, __ chapters, plus front/back matter
Audience	Who buys this, in one sentence
Format	e.g. trade paperback 6x9 and Kindle, self-published via KDP
Delivery to editor	Date
Target ship date	Date

About the author

One paragraph, from your facts file. Nothing in it the facts file cannot support.

The voice (read this first)

The section that matters most. What distinguishes your voice from everyone else on your shelf. Then two lists, drawn from your voice profile:

Tics that stay. The things that look like mistakes and are not. Signature openers, deliberate em-dashes, one-sentence paragraphs, recurring metaphors, anchor phrases that reference a story. Name each one so it is not "fixed."

Moves to push back on. Where your prose drifts when it drifts — consultant-speak, jargon that was never translated, fear-selling, overselling yourself. Ask for a query, not a rewrite.

Scope of the edit

What I am asking for: e.g. a combined line edit and copyedit against Chicago.

What I am not asking for: e.g. developmental editing. Structure is locked.

The disqualifying rule: An edit is not a rewrite. A sample that rewrites my sentences instead of correcting them is an automatic no. Say it in exactly the words you will score against.

Style conventions

Item	Decision
Style guide	e.g. Chicago Manual of Style (note edition on the style sheet)
Spelling	e.g. U.S. English, Merriam-Webster
Serial comma	Yes / No
Numbers	Your rule
Em-dashes	Closed / spaced; note if heavy use is intentional
Quotations	Curly quotes; block-quote threshold
Citations	How light or heavy; what to verify
Acronyms	Defined on first use; query undefined ones

Timeline

Delivery date to editor, turnaround you need, ship date, and what is running in parallel (cover, production).

Deliverables

- Edited manuscript in Word with Track Changes on
- Author query list — explicit ("Did you mean X or Y?"), not generic ("clarify")
- Style sheet: names, terms, hyphenations, capitalizations, deliberate non-standard choices
- Optional one-page closing memo on anything structural for the next edition

Compensation

Ask for their fee structure, or state your budget.

How to respond

What you want back: relevant experience, a quote, calendar confirmation, and a one-paragraph reaction to the sample chapter. Ask for their instincts, not a free sample edit — then, for the finalists, request the same short sample edit from each so you can score them against the disqualifying rule.

Sample chapter

Attach one representative chapter, ~3,000 words, your most recently revised. Say what it is representative of.